

A project report on
**“A Study on Hashtag Effectiveness in Boosting Social Media
Engagement”**

BY

MR. AHMED FAZIL

4SF23BA006

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Post guidance of Internal Guide

Dr. Prima Dsouza

Assistant Professor

Department of Business Administration



Department of Business Administration

SAHYADRI COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING & MANAGEMENT

“Sahyadri campus” N.H.48, Adyar, Mangalore-575007

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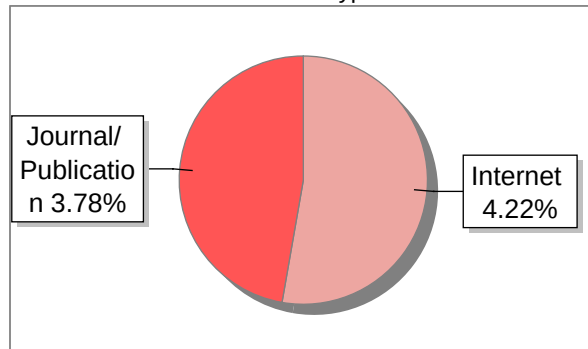
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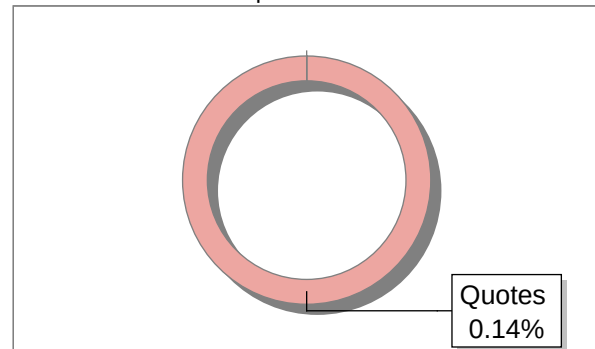
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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that **Mr. AHMED FAZIL** bearing USN **4SF23BA006** is a bonafide student of the Master of Business Administration Program at Sahyadri College of Engineering & Management (2023-2025), an autonomous institution, affiliated to Visvesvaraya Technological University, Belagavi. The Project report on "**A Study on Hashtag Effectiveness in Boosting Social Media Engagement**" is prepared by him under the guidance of **Dr. Prima Dsouza**, Department of Business Administration, Sahyadri College of Engineering & Management, in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Master of Business Administration of Visvesvaraya Technological University, Belagavi Karnataka.

Signature of Internal Guide

Signature of HOD

Director
Master of Business Administration
Sahyadri College of Engineering & Management
An Autonomous Institution

Signature of Principal

Principal
Sahyadri College of Engineering & Management
An Autonomous Institution
Mangaluru

DECLARATION

I, **Ahmed Fazil**, hereby declare that the Project report entitled “**A Study on Hashtag Effectiveness in Boosting Social Media Engagement**” prepared by me under the guidance of **Dr. Prima Dsouza**, Department of Business Administration, Sahyadri College of Engineering & Management, an Autonomous Institution, Mangalore. I also declare that this Project work is towards the partial fulfilment of the university regulations for the award of the degree of Master of Business Administration by Visvesvaraya Technological University, Belgaum. I have undergone a summer project for a period of eight weeks. I further declare that this Project is based on the original study undertaken by me and has not been submitted for the award of any degree/diploma from any other University / Institution.

Place: Mangalore

Name of the Student: Ahmed Fazil

Date:

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Name:
Ahmed Fazil

USN:
4SF23BA006

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In this research, the use of hashtags as an effective marketing tool has been investigated, and how content source, format, emotional tone, and visibility influence user activity on social media has been explored. Using data from 340 participants and statistical tests, the study concluded that influencer posts, visual formats, and emotionally charged tones considerably outperformed brand-only, text formats, or neutral ones. Hashtags were demonstrated to function as strong indicators that not only enhance visibility but also establish more solid brand-consumer relationships. The research concludes that strategic hashtag application—backed by influencer partnerships, visual narrative, and ongoing performance tracking—provides brands with a competitive edge in the current digital market.

Chapter 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 The Emergence of Social Media Marketing and Hashtag Culture

Over the last two decades, the digital landscape has experienced remarkable growth, reshaping how individuals and businesses interact. Among the many forces that have driven this transformation, social media has been the most influential. Once viewed as platforms for casual conversations or sharing personal updates, social media channels have now developed into highly sophisticated ecosystems that influence consumer behavior, shape public opinion, and create new opportunities for business growth.

For contemporary companies, social media is not an add-on to their marketing operations but a requirement. With billions of individuals employing sites like Instagram, Facebook, X (previously Twitter), YouTube, and TikTok on a daily basis, such platforms have become the pillars of branding operations. They bring immediate access to active, speaking, and engaged audiences. In the process, however, extensive reach has its downside. A brand's success hinges not just on visibility but also on how well it breaks through in a competitive marketplace in which the consumer is bombarded with thousands of messages in each hour.

In response to this threat, marketers are constantly probing new ways to get noticed. One of them that has left a long-term mark is the hashtag. Originally presented as an operational device to organize discussions, hashtags have become cultural signifiers of online communication. They not only enable individuals to find content but also enable businesses to tie their brand message to broader social or cultural stories.

The function of hashtags has far exceeded their initial intention. What began as a method of making subjects searchable has become an instrument that can group thousands of posts around a single subject. For customers, hashtags provide a gateway to sustained conversations. For companies, hashtags are a portal to visibility, enabling content to be found by audiences beyond their direct followers.

A carefully selected hashtag has the power to turn an average marketing campaign into a movement. Campaigns like #ShareACoke for Coca-Cola or #LikeAGirl for Always are popular examples of how hashtags can form emotional connections, invite users to be part of the conversation, and propagate messages far beyond the brand's control. These illustrate the fact that hashtags are not mere symbols but as strategic tools that integrate language, emotion, and collective participation.

Another benefit of hashtags is that they are measurable. Unlike many forms of traditional advertising, which are impossible to measure in terms of interest, hashtags have a discernible digital trace. Businesses can study how many people employ a hashtag, where it's being used, and what kind of discourse it engenders. The fact that they can track performance makes hashtags useful not just as communications tools but also as market research and consumer intelligence tools.

However, not all hashtags are successful to the same extent. While some turn viral, others do not create any response. This disparity leads to a very relevant question: what makes a successful hashtag campaign?

The effectiveness of hashtags is not random—it rests on a number of interrelated factors that determine how audiences receive and interact with content. The current research finds five such factors and examines their role in determining engagement results.

- First is the source of content. Posts created by the brand itself may build authority and consistency, while posts that involve collaborations with influencers, celebrities, or even consumers may expand reach and add credibility. Determining which approach works better in different contexts is a key concern.
- Second is the content type. Social media updates can be used for many purposes: they can educate, entertain, or invoke social interaction. Any one of these purposes can mold user engagement in a different way. For instance, informative content can be valuable but may not necessarily always create the same kind of excitement as humorous or emotionally charged updates.
- Third is content format. Visual media, in the form of videos, tend to excel over static images or text due to their dynamism and arresting nature. TikTok and Instagram Reels have proven that consumers are attracted to short, visually engaging videos. In other circumstances, images or infographics can do a better job of conveying brief messages.
- The fourth element is emotional tone. Humor, storytelling, or inspiration used in the posts are more likely to engage audiences on a deeper level. Consumer psychology studies indicate that emotional content is more likely to be remembered, shared, and talked about than neutral content.
- Lastly, visibility of hashtags is also at play. There are those posts that put hashtags forward in captions or graphics and those that employ them discreetly. The location and

emphasis of hashtags can influence the perception of the users toward the brand and whether or not they interact with the content.

By combining the analysis of these factors together, this research hopes to find patterns that account for why certain hashtags thrive and others go unnoticed.

1.2 Study Aims and Scope

The primary aim of this research is to explore how hashtags affect consumer interaction on social media. To obtain this, the research investigates five principal aspects: content source, content type, content format, tone of emotions, and hashtag exposure. Through investigating these factors, the research seeks to determine effective strategies brands can use to enhance their online campaigns.

The focus of this study goes beyond likes, comments, and shares. Although these factors are useful indicators of exposure, they fail to measure completely the intensity of consumer engagement. Engagement also encompasses intangible elements such as interest, participation, and consumers' willingness to engage in conversations actively. Through the integration of both quantitative and experiential insights, the present research aims to present a comprehensive picture of how hashtags influence engagement.

The conclusions of this study are anticipated to provide data-driven recommendations that will help marketers make better decisions. For multinational companies or small businesses, knowing how to craft successful hashtag campaigns can enhance visibility, strengthen relationships with customers, and improve brand loyalty.

1.3 Why This Study Matters for Modern Marketing

In today's digital landscape, brands fight not just against direct competitors but also against millions of voices and messages that inundate social media daily. Grabbing consumer attention is challenging, and retaining it is even more challenging. This truth necessitates that businesses acquire approaches that are at once innovative and effective. Hashtags, though simple, have the potential to be that when optimized.

The value of this research is that it can demonstrate the influence hashtags have on engagement. By analyzing the effects of various variables on hashtag popularity, the study connects practice and theory and provides practical recommendations for organizations. For small brands, a good hashtag strategy can get them noticed without spending money on big ad budgets. For big corporations, it can make their campaigns competitive and current.

In addition, social media sites are ever-changing, presenting new features and algorithms that affect prominence. How hashtags work now might not be the same as how they will work later. By studying their influence now, this research adds to an extended perspective on how online marketing tools evolve and continue to work well in the long term.

Finally, hashtags are not just symbols that occur at the start of words—they're tools of participation, connection, and identity in the digital age. Deciphering the conditions that enable their effectiveness, this study offers pertinent knowledge that can inform businesses on how to develop campaigns that resonate with people and maintain consumer engagement in an expanding competitive market.

Chapter 2

REVIEW OF LITERATURE & RESEARCH GAP

2.1 Literature Review

S. No	Focus (Variable based)	Contribution (findings/insights)	Reference (in text APA citation)
1	Content source	The research discusses the use of hashtags by advocacy organizations, noting its success in mobilizing and engaging constituents. It investigates inter-sectoral variation and links hashtag adoption to social media message effectiveness, focusing on hashtags as a tool of strategy for visibility and engagement.	Saxton, G. D., Niyirora, J., Guo, C., & Waters, R. D. (2015).
2	Content source	Trademarking hashtags enormously improves social media audience responsiveness and information sharing, especially for companies that have relatively low followers. Successful engagement processes need to include certain communication and language styles in order to maximize the marketing advantage of trademarked hashtags.	Kumar, N., Kumar, N., Qiu, L., & Kumar, S. (2017). https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=2997653
3	Content source, User engagement	The article highlights that accurate framing in hashtags substantially boosts mobilization and participation in online social movements, positing that a successful hashtag can similarly enhance visibility and participation in social media campaigns by demarcating issues clearly and stimulating user interaction.	Zuraida, Z. (2023). https://doi.org/10.12928/channel.v1i1.339
4	Content format	The article highlights hashtags' extensive part in social movements, amplifying communication and self-expression on social media. Though it concentrates on activism, it suggests that hashtags can likewise increase awareness and interaction in social media promotion through decentralized knowledge sharing.	Agustya, S. V., Natalia, K., & Irwansyah, I. (2023). https://doi.org/10.58344/jws.v2i10.447
5	Content format,	The paper covers extensive research on hashtags, describing their application in hashtag activism and	La Rocca, G., & Artieri, G. B. (2022).

	Content source	metrics, which indicates their usefulness as devices for visibility and engagement for social media marketing, though certain strategies are not explained.	https://doi.org/10.3389/fsoc.2022.1081603
6	Content format, User engagement	The essay explores hashtag campaigns such as Coca-Cola's #ShareaCoke and Calvin Klein's #MyCalvins, pointing out their contribution to audience agential labor within the creation of content, rendering them producers and advertisers, hence increasing exposure and interaction and uncovering the exploitation of social media users.	Yacoub, N. https://doi.org/10.32920/ryerson.14649276.v1
7	Content format, Content source	The. research emphasizes that hashtag participation greatly helps to boost brand awareness in Indonesia's beauty market, with successful features being the use of English and the mention of brand names, and thus hashtags being an essential weapon for publicity and participation in social media advertising.	Priharta, M. (2023). https://doi.org/10.55057/ijbtm.2023.5.3.25
8	Content format	Hashtags greatly increase the visibility and engagement of social media marketing, especially on Instagram. According to the study, their use increases likes and comments, thus enhancing follower engagement with hotel brands, such as the Ushuaia Beach Hotel and Six Senses Douro Valley.	Almeida, S. (2022). https://doi.org/10.1080/1528008x.2022.2050876
9	Emotional cues	The paper discusses the usefulness of hashtags, such as #OptOutside, in increasing brand awareness and online discussion, identifying their function in social media marketing as engagement and attention tools in both online and offline communication.	Demirel, A. (2020). https://doi.org/10.1080/15252019.2020.1840460
10	Emotional cues, Content source	The article points out that hashtags are of particular importance in online marketing, raising visibility and interaction by grounding web discussions. They allow for meaningful conversation in brand communities,	Naraine, M. L., Pegoraro, A., & Wear, H. (2021). https://doi.org/10.1177/2167479519878676

		making them a useful mechanism for organizations to reach their audience.	
11	Emotional cues	The article points out hashtags as content promoting tools that increase content discoverability and community interaction on Twitter, making it easier for navigation and optimizing tweet visibility, thereby being effective in social media marketing through interlinking of contents and creation of user interactions.	Yang, L., Sun, T., Zhang, M., & Mei, Q. (2012). https://doi.org/10.1145/2187836.2187872
12	Emotional cues	The article points out that hashtags notably promote visibility and interaction on social media advertising through enhanced transmission of marketing content. It cites important factors in hashtags that can adequately correct shortcomings in existing social media marketing practices.	Zain, S. Z. M., Hussin, A. R. C., & Selamat, H. (2019). https://doi.org/10.1109/ICRIIS48246.2019.9073657
13	Emotional cues	Hashtags are very useful in increasing visibility and interaction in social media marketing by congregating content based on shared themes, building online communities, and supporting advocacy campaigns. It is effective because they draw in the desired audiences and support user-generated content naturally.	Kola, B., & Zhezha, V. (2023). https://doi.org/10.36941/jesr-2023-0087
14	User engagement , Content source	The research highlights that hashtag engagement, specifically #Peoplewearoemahetnik, significantly influences brand image for UKM Oemah Etnik, demonstrating its effectiveness as a tool for visibility and engagement in social media marketing, with a 45% impact on brand perception.	Oktavia, Y. (2019). https://repository.unair.ac.id/87165/
15	User engagement	The paper evaluates the efficacy of hashtag campaigns in health awareness using social media and finds that although the posts are credible and pertinent, they are less popular. This indicates that credibility and engagement should be factors to be taken into account for successful campaigns.	George, N., Britto, D. R., Krishnan, V., Dass, L. M., Prasanth, H. A., & Aravindhana, V. (2018).

			https://doi.org/10.4103/JEHP.JEHP_37_18
16	User engagement	Hashtags increase social media marketing visibility and engagement by acting as content markers and creating a sense of belonging. Their universal application from sarcasm to formal communication illustrates their efficacy in binding users and projecting messages in online platforms.	Thiemann, T., & Moutchnik, A. (2021). https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-658-32085-0_7
17	User engagement	Hashtags enhance discoverability and visibility of social media content and facilitate information sharing. They aid in theming and drawing in audiences, rendering them an important resource for health professionals in disseminating reliable health information and boosting audience engagement.	Anand, R., & Cheema, S. (2022). https://doi.org/10.5339/qproc.2022.ehil2021.8
18	User engagement	The essay explains hashtags as critical means of information exchange in social media, promoting visibility and interaction. They enable exchange of knowledge and networking within communities, thus promoting awareness and aiding in content creation between social media users and followers.	Ayu, M., Tengku Izhar, T. A., Shahibi, M. S., & Kamaruzzaman, M. R. S. (2022). https://doi.org/10.5296/ifb.v9i1.20016
19	Content format, User engagement	The research examines the impact of various visual features of Instagram images, including type and people presence, on user engagement. Results indicate that images with people yielded substantially more likes, underlining the relevance of content form to driving engagement.	Gao, Y., Xie, Z., Sun, L., Xu, C., & Li, D. (2021). https://doi.org/10.2196/29600
20	Content format, User engagement	This study examines the impact of different visual elements of Instagram posts—videos, posts with people, and posts without people—on levels of engagement. Findings show that videos yield the	Ghazali, E. M., Abdul Rahman, W. N., & Mutum, D. S. (2021). https://doi.org/10.4018/IJESMA.295960

		highest level of engagement, followed by posts with people, and posts without people.	
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2.2 Research Gaps

Though hashtags are generally known to be used for raising one's visibility and engagement on social media, there is no rigorous study that examines how factors such as:

- Content source (brand-generated vs. collaborations)
- Content format (text, image, video)
- Emotional signals (informativity, humor)

shape consumer interaction. This research seeks to address this gap by examining these variables and their effects on user interaction, and what can be learned about more successful hashtag approaches.

Chapter 3
RESEARCH DESIGN

3.1 Problem Statement

As the modern world becomes more digital, social media has become one of the most powerful tools for brand discussion, customer engagement, and relationship building. Instagram, Facebook, Twitter (X), and LinkedIn are not just networking sites but have become living marketplaces where brands compete for consumer attention. In the midst of such competition, hashtags have emerged as a hub of digital marketing strategy.

Hashtags serve multiple purposes: they make content discoverable, trigger brand-driven conversations, and mobilize fan engagement in campaigns. Brands rely on hashtags to drive reach and engagement, particularly when launching new products, running promotional campaigns, or establishing customer loyalty. Nevertheless, though widely applied, the overall value of hashtags to drive quantifiable user engagement remains obscure.

Most businesses adopt hashtags based on industry trends or actions from competitors without fully understanding the factors that render some better than others. While some campaigns become popular worldwide, others do not receive even moderate attention. These differences present an immense research puzzle: What determines a successful or failed hashtag in mobilizing users?

Empirical findings demonstrate that user engagement is not most predominantly triggered by hashtags but by a combination of corresponding situations such as content provenance (brand, influencer, or peer-generated content), content format (video, image, or text), and affective valence (humorous, inspirational, neutral, or informative). Moreover, the manner in which hashtags are applied—e.g., whether they are visible, where they are located, and how relevant they are to the post—seems to mediate their impact. However, scholarly work related to how these variables engage to affect engagement is scarce, particularly within the Indian context where adoption of social media is increasing at a fast rate.

The gap is even more significant considering that brands invest a significant amount of money in social media advertising. In the absence of evidence-based results, marketers risk losing money as they fail to maximize opportunities for engaging with consumers. It is therefore critical to conduct a systematic examination that not only looks into hashtags in isolation but also considers how content-facilitating factors and hashtag approaches collectively affect user engagement results.

Grounded on these results, this research aims to address the following principal problem:

- Though popularly used in online promotions, there is yet no adequate empirical understanding of how content characteristics (source, form, and emotional cues) and hashtag strategies (visibility and relevance) influence user engagement behavior such as likes, sharing, comments, and clicks.

Through completion of the lacuna here, the research will provide marketers, brands, and social media planners concrete knowledge on how to build hashtag campaigns that not only become discoverable but also become genuinely interactive, hence making overall digital marketing more effective.⁶ Objectives

3.2 Theoretical Framework

To appreciate the power of hashtags in engaging customers, it is critical to situate the research within well-documented theoretical lenses. Theory helps us understand why some social media approaches work while others do not. Three such theories—Signal Theory, Media Richness Theory, and Consumer Engagement Theory—are central to this research. Together, they clarify how hashtags work as cues for communication, the way content form and tone influence user reaction, and the way consumers emotionally and behaviorally interact with branded content.

I. Signal Theory: Hashtags as Social and Branding Cues

Signal Theory is especially useful in situations where people decide with limited information. According to it, people use signals—messages that minimize uncertainty and steer judgments—when judging products, services, or messages. In social media, hashtags serve as such signals.

A hashtag does not only classify content but also provides immediate indications of its relevance, subject, or brand linkage. As an instance, an open community tag #ThrowbackThursday indicates retrospective or reflective material, whereas a branded tag like #AdidasOriginals immediately informs product and campaign association. Where hashtags are

explicit, observable, and meaningfully contextual, they function as cognitive shortcuts reducing effort on the part of the audience.

In marketing, it is important because attention is fleeting and users are Information Overload victims. If the hashtag of a post indicates relevance or resonates with a popular theme, the chances of engagement become very high. In this research, visibility of hashtags is thus considered to be a central independent variable, symbolizing the strength of the signal being transmitted to potential viewers.

II. Media Richness Theory: The Role of Format and Emotional Appeal

After a post gains initial attention through cues, the real issue is whether the content can be maintained and spark interaction. This is where Media Richness Theory (MRT) provides useful insight. MRT supposes that various media differ in their potential to facilitate information, and richer media—media supporting more cues, more immediate feedback, and emotional richness—are more capable of generating interaction.

On social media, content types vary in richness. A brief clip of video that is humorous or emotive is richer than text per se, since it offers several sensory and contextual cues. Likewise, images, memes, and infographics are richer than plain text blocks or mere links.

In addition to format, tone and emotional cues contained in the material also contribute to richness. Those posts that resort to humor, inspiration, or everyday conversation are more likely to come across as human-like and relatable, hence improving emotional resonance. Conversely, neutral or formal posts can come across as remote and less engaging to engage with.

For the purpose of this research, content type (text, photo, video, or link) and emotional signals (humor, informal tone, inspiration) are studied as independent variables in accordance with Media Richness Theory. They provide reasons why some types of posts just tend to get more likes, shares, and comments than others.

III. Consumer Engagement Theory: Emotional, Cognitive, and Behavioral Connections

While signals and media richness draw attention, Consumer Engagement Theory (CET) tells us what comes next: how people engage with and take in branded content. CET maintains that engagement is not a one-time act but a multi-dimensional process incorporating emotional, cognitive, and behavioral reactions.

- Emotional engagement takes place when users experience something—like happiness, humor, or inspiration—while engaging with content.
- Cognitive engagement entails cognitive investment, where the users process and think about the message of the brand.
- Behavioral engagement is evidenced by behaviors such as liking, commenting, sharing, clicking, or even generating user-generated content about the brand.

In this research, engagement is quantified in two broad measures:

- 1) Observable social media actions (likes, shares, comments, clicks).
- 2) More intensive involvement, such as how engaged or focused users are toward the brand following exposure to content.

By integrating the views of Signal Theory and Media Richness Theory, CET explains the result—why users transition from passive scrolling to active engagement. It is the main dependent variable of the study: user engagement.

3.3 Conceptual Model of the Study

Combining these viewpoints, this research formulates a conceptual model that ties independent variables—content source, content format, and emotional cues—to the dependent variable, user engagement.

The model depicts how:

- Hashtags are cues that draw initial interest.
- Content format and emotional tone, accounted for by media richness, maintain interest.

- These factors interact to affect consumer engagement levels, which are comprised of emotional, cognitive, and behavioral aspects.

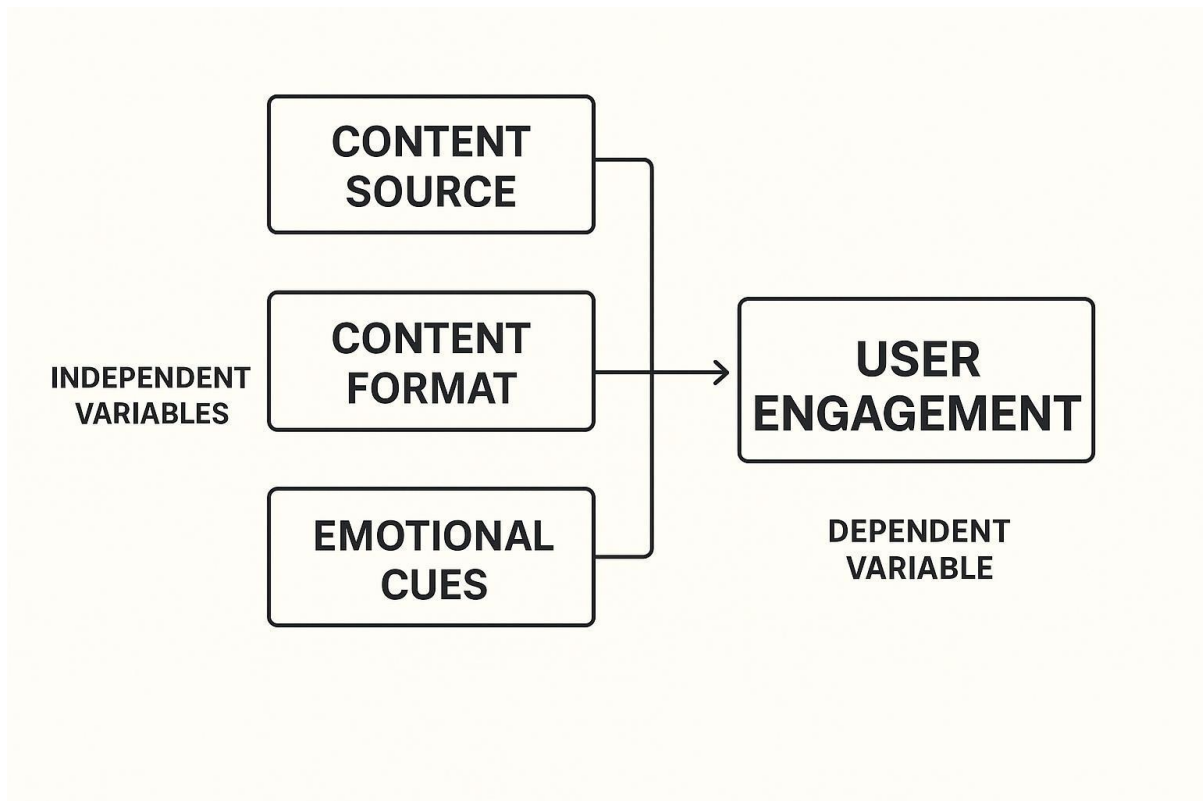


figure 1: conceptual model for the study

a. Content Source → User Engagement

Where content comes from largely determines how much audience trust and involvement it will garner. When the content is produced only by brands, the post is likely to feel formal, promotional, or overly managed. Although such a post can still get to the people, it tends to miss the human touch that contemporary digital consumers yearn for.

Conversely, when brands partner with influencers, celebrities, or popular creators, the source of the content shifts in terms of perception. Such collaborations bring credibility, since influencers become social proof for the brand. Their endorsement lessens skepticism, especially for younger consumers who prioritize authenticity. Furthermore, collective posts gain from the influencer's audience, which increases the content's visibility and organic reach.

This research, thus, takes content source as a key to engagement determination, hypothesizing that co-created content will create interaction values higher than brand-exclusive updates.

b. Content Format → User Engagement

Just as important is the form in which a message comes across. Social media has various forms—text updates, static pictures, links, GIFs, and videos. Among these, video-based and image-based posts tend to be rated as more engaging by users than plain text or hyperlinks.

More rich media can support multiple cues and effectively communicate emotional undertones, states Media Richness Theory. Videos, for example, combine motion, sound, and images and are thus especially well-suited to storytelling. Images and infographics, being less rich than video, yet more engaging than text alone, can command attention quickly amidst busy newsfeeds.

Therefore, this study suggests that content type affects not just how soon audiences perceive posts but also to what extent they engage with them, richer media types being anticipated to produce greater engagement.

c. Emotional Cues → User Engagement

Lastly, tone and emotional appeal are crucial to building substantive consumer engagement. Blog posts that contain humor, friendly chatter, or uplifting storytelling engage more intimately with consumers than blog posts that are neutral or formal in tone. Humor produces immediate relatability, inspiration inspires shares, and informal tones tend to make brands seem more human.

Emotional triggers serve as a psychological catalyst for emotional engagement, reinforcing cognitive and behavioral reactions. For instance, a humorous or inspirational post is not only more likely to get liked or shared but could also lead users to build a closer relationship with the brand.

For this purpose, emotional signals are handled as a vital component within this model, anticipated to highly contribute to engagement on various levels—likes, shares, comments, and brand connection.

3.4 Research Methodology

The research approach is the cornerstone of any piece of academic work since it stipulates the design, methodology, and methods of data collection and analysis. For this effectiveness of hashtags in affecting user engagement project, the methodology has been crafted with utmost care to make the findings both valid and reliable. The sub-sections below detail the research design, population and sample, data collection procedures, variables, measurement instruments, and data analysis methods.

A. Research Design

The study utilizes a descriptive research design to examine how hashtags influence user interactions on social media sites. The descriptive design suits this study best because it enables the researcher to view existing behaviors, recognize patterns, and make sense of relationships without intervening or changing any variables.

The purpose of this design is not to determine causality but to achieve a complete description of how content source, content form, and emotion cues—being moderated by use of hashtags—are related to engagement results like likes, shares, and comments. By integrating quantitative user behavior measurement with qualitative information from content features, this design guarantees a complete grasping of the research problem.

B. Population and Sample

The sample of this research is composed of active social media users who consistently engage with brand posts. As hashtags are a cross-platform element, the scope encompasses users across platforms like Instagram, Facebook, and Twitter (X), which all heavily depend on hashtags for both discovering content and targeting audiences.

As a method to choose the respondents, this research employs a purposive sampling method, specifically targeting people who:

- Are known to use hashtags, and
- Have interacted (liked, shared, or commented) on branded content over the last three months.

This way, the participants not only know about hashtags but are also applicable to the scenario of brand interaction.

C. Data Collection Methods

Two complementarities data sources were used:

- 1) Primary Data – Gleaned from a systematic online survey conducted via social networking sites and word of mouth. The survey contained both closed-ended questions and Likert-scale questions to gauge user sentiment, attitudes towards various content types, emotional reaction, and extent of engagement for hashtagged content.
- 2) Secondary Data – From academic research, industry reports, whitepapers, and social media analysis. This information formed the basis for the literature review and acted as a baseline for interpreting the primary study results.

This dual-stream strategy allowed the study to integrate first-hand information with founded knowledge, increasing depth as well as credibility.

D. Variables and Measurement

In order to analyze the research aims, the study delineates the following major variables:

I. Independent Variables:

- CONTENT SOURCE (brand-only, influencer partnership, celebrity endorsement)
- CONTENT FORMAT (video, image, text, link)
- EMOTIONAL CUES (humor, neutral, inspirational, casual tone)

II. Dependent Variable:

User Engagement (measured in terms of likes, comments, shares, clicks, and perceptions of engagement strength).

Measurement Tools:

- A five-point Likert scale was used for perceptual questions, with Strongly Disagree (1) and Strongly Agree (5).

- Quantitative measures in the form of number of likes, shares, comments, and click-throughs reported by the respondents or found through post samples were used to measure behavioral engagement.

This integration of perceptual and behavioral measures enhances the construct's validity.

E. Data Analysis Tools

The data was coded and analyzed using both SPSS and Microsoft Excel with care. These were used due to their capability of handling large amounts of data effectively and generating both descriptive and inferential statistical results.

- Descriptive Statistics (mean, percentage, frequency distributions) were employed to describe demographic information and overall participation trends.
- Inferential Statistics such as correlation analysis and regression analysis were used to test hypotheses, quantify the strength of independent and dependent variables relationship, and evaluate the role of hashtags as moderators.

Through the utilization of these instruments, the research ensured that results were backed up by numerical tendencies and statistical affirmation.

3.5 Objectives of this study

- To find out if the source of a post (whether made by users or brands) affects how much people engage with hashtagged content.
- To explore whether the way content is presented (like videos, images, or other formats) changes how much engagement it gets when hashtags are used.
- To understand how the feeling or tone of a post (such as funny, inspiring, or neutral) impacts user engagement with hashtagged posts.

3.6 Research Hypotheses

In line with the research objectives, the following hypotheses have been formulated to guide the study:

Objective 1: Source of Post

- H0: There is no difference in engagement between user-made and brand-made posts with hashtags.
- H1: Posts made by users get different engagement than posts made by brands when hashtags are used.

Objective 2: Content Format

- H0: Content format does not affect engagement on hashtagged posts.
- H1: The way content is presented (video, image, etc.) changes how much engagement posts with hashtags get.

Objective 3: Emotional Tone

- H0: Emotional tone has no effect on engagement with hashtagged posts.
- H1: The tone or feeling of a post influences how much people engage with hashtagged posts.

Chapter 4
ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

4.1 Interpretation of Data

1) Age Group

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
18–24	135	40%
25–34	128	38%
35–44	47	14%
below 18	20	6%
45 and above	10	3%

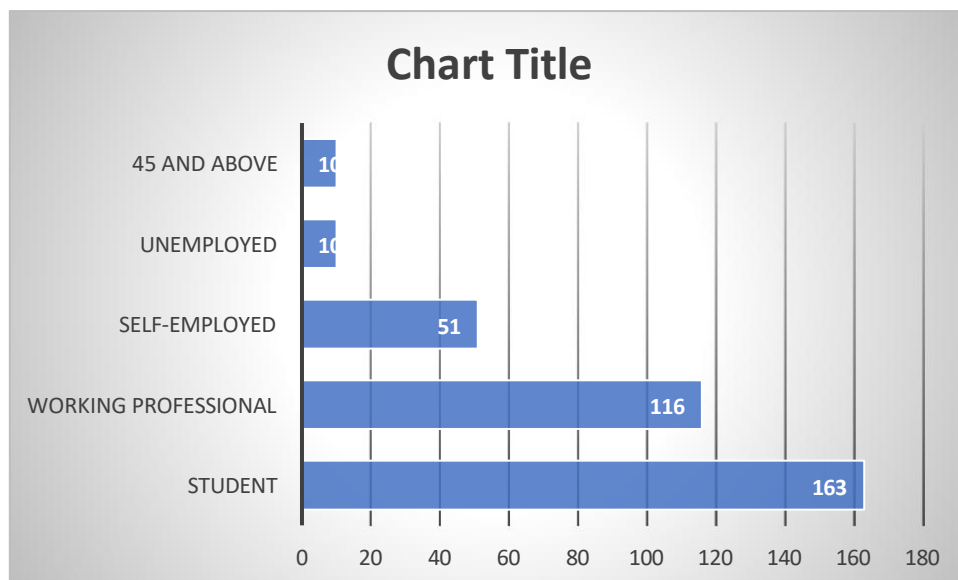


Figure 2: Age Distribution

Interpretation

78% are aged 18–34, the most active social media users. This is exactly the demographic most active in online environments. Younger users are more experimental and receptive to hashtag trends. Brands marketing to them can optimize campaign efficiency.

2) Gender

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Male	178	52%
Female	162	48%

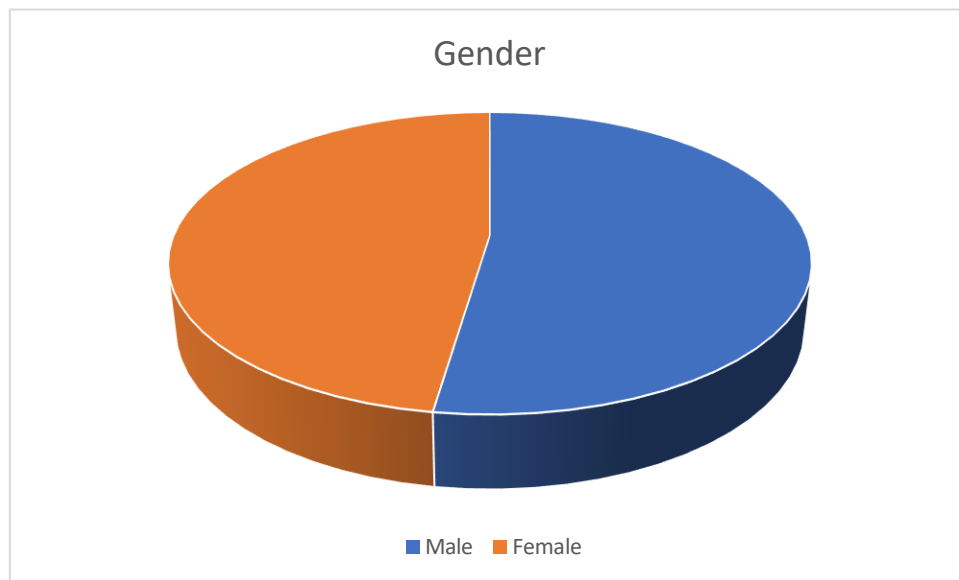


Figure 3: Gender Distribution

Interpretation

The sample is equally balanced, having 52% males and 48% females. The balance prevents results from being skewed due to gender bias. Insights on the use of hashtags from both genders are equally contributed. This means findings can be applied across broader segments of the audience.

3) Education Level

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Postgraduate	186	55%
Undergraduate	124	36%
High School	20	6%
PhD	10	3%

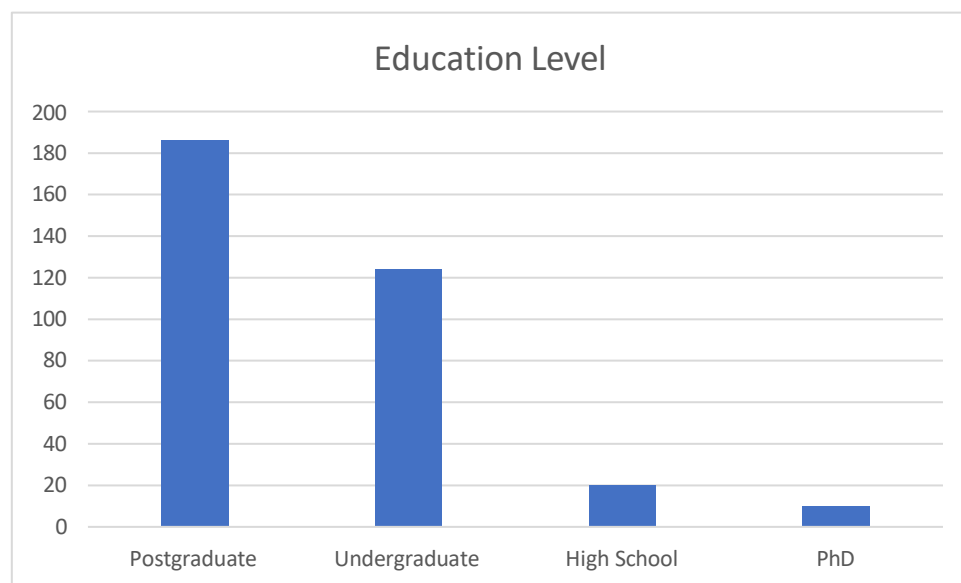


Figure 4: Education Level

Interpretation

91% are either undergraduate or postgraduate-educated. This suggests the audience is highly educated and technologically literate. Educated audiences might be more critical of hashtags. This offers brands a sophisticated but demanding consumer market.

4) Occupation

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Student	163	48%
Working Professional	116	34%
Self-employed	51	15%
Unemployed	10	3%



Figure 5: Occupation

Interpretation

48% are students and 34% are working professionals. This underlines that the audience is predominantly youth and early-career individuals. They are influenced by their learning and professional development. Such groups are more likely to explore new online trends such as hashtags.

Social Media Frequency

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
More than 5 times	97	29%
Rarely	84	25%
1–2 times	83	24%
3–5 times	76	22%

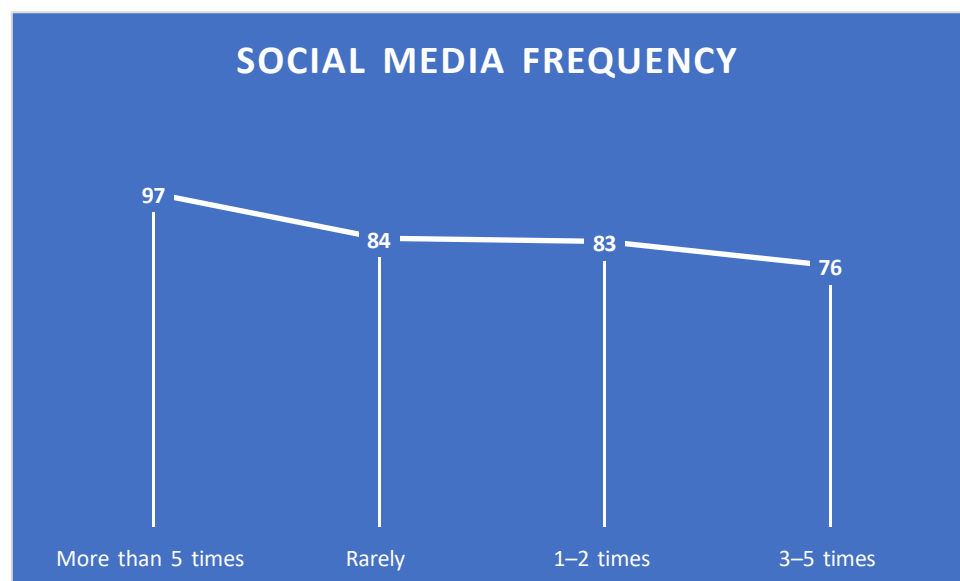


Figure 6: Social Media Frequency

Interpretation

29% access social media over 5 times a day, with just 25% doing it sparingly. This indicates that the majority of users are very active online. Constant use translates to more chances for brands to interact with hashtags. The digital platform is therefore good terrain for marketing campaigns. Platform Preference.

Platform Preference

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Instagram	122	36%
X (Twitter)	83	24%
Facebook	69	20%
LinkedIn	43	13%
YouTube	18	5%
Snapchat	4	1%
Whatsapp	1	0%

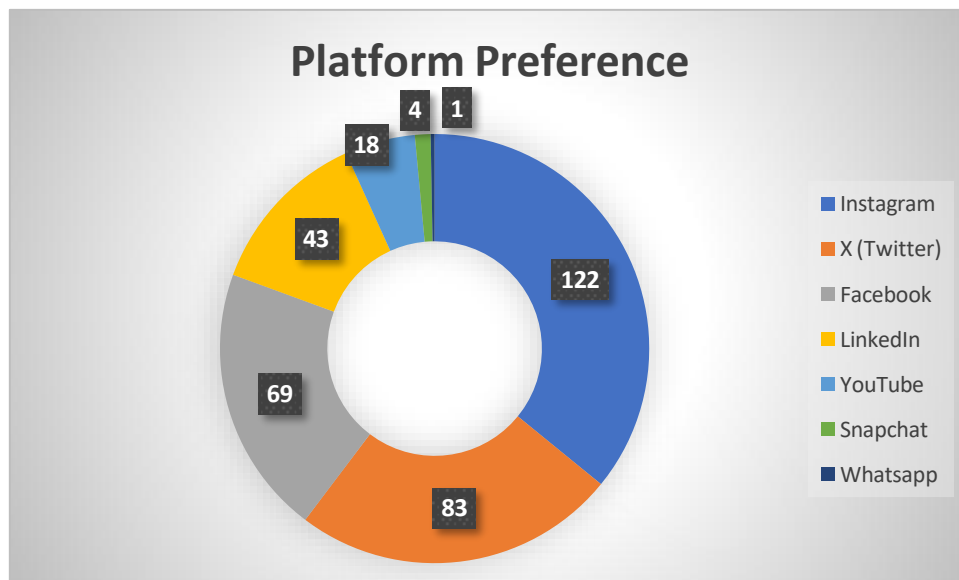


Figure 7: Platform Preference

Interpretation

Instagram (36%) leads, followed by X (24%) and Facebook (20%). This shows Instagram leads hashtag-driven interaction. Younger audience segments particularly prefer Instagram, consistent with its visual character. Thus, Instagram needs to be a primary target for hashtag marketing.

Noticing Hashtags

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Sometimes	163	48%
Yes	126	37%
No	51	15%

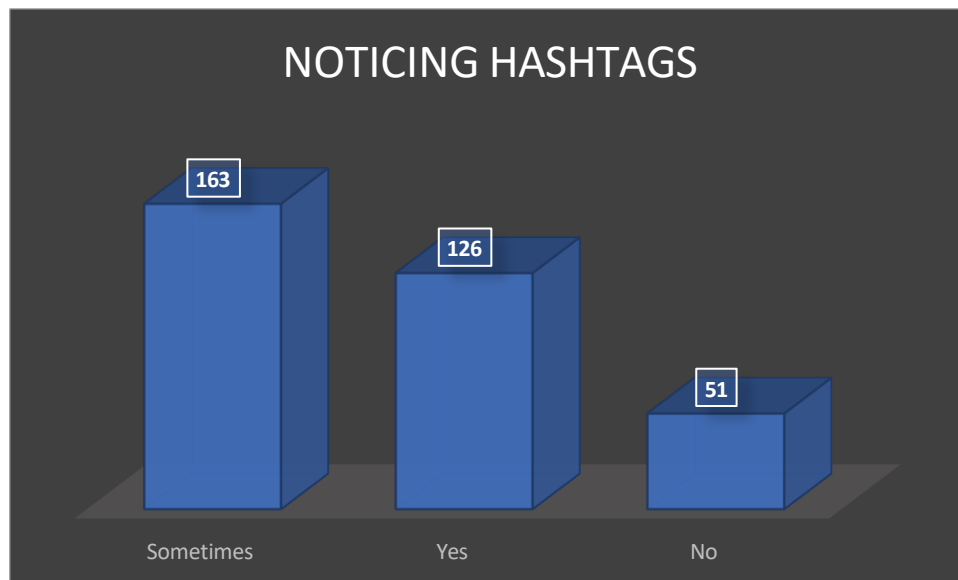


Figure 8: Noticing Hashtags

Interpretation

85% do see hashtags, although close to half report only "sometimes." This indicates that though hashtags are apparent, their utility is uneven. Design, relevance, and placement influence user notice. To get the most visibility, hashtags need to stay contextually strong.

Clicked on Hashtag (Yes/No)

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Yes	232	68%
No	108	32%

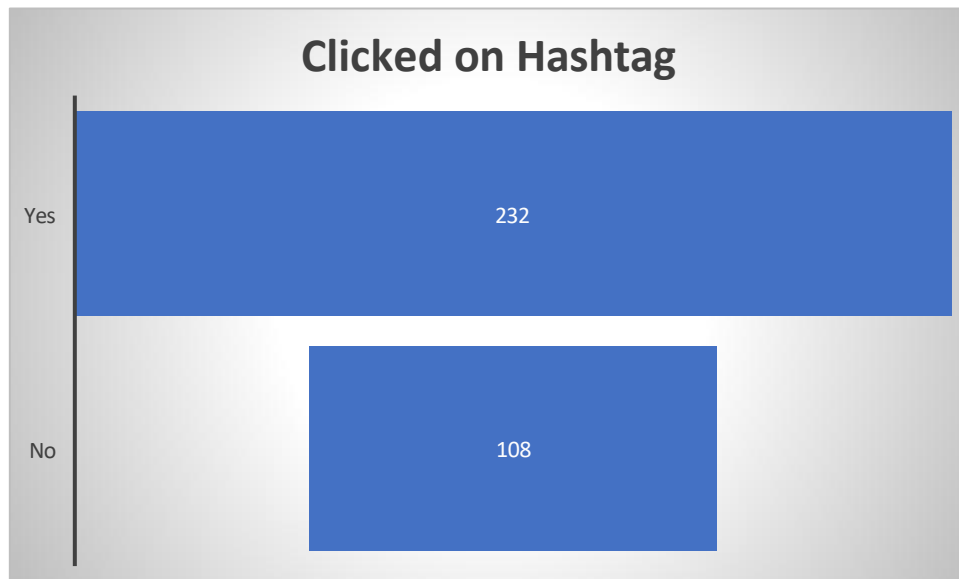


Figure 9: Clicked on Hashtag

Interpretation

68% have tapped on hashtags, proving that they drive discovery and engagement. Yet, almost one-third still don't actively engage with hashtags themselves. This indicates that there is unreached potential within hashtag campaigns. Brands need to create hashtags which foster curiosity and clicks.

Influencer vs Brand

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	168	49%
Agree	83	24%
Neutral	59	17%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I find influencer posts more engaging than brand-only posts.

340 responses

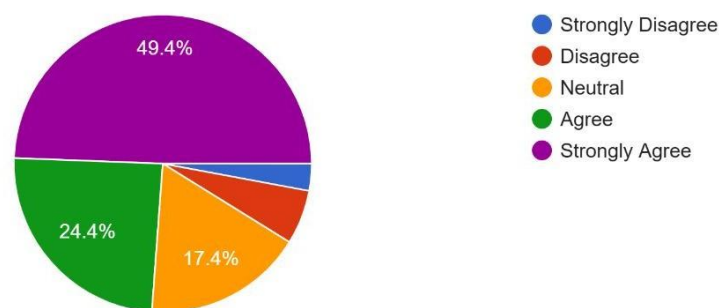


Figure 10: Influencer v/s Brand

Interpretation

73% find influencer posts more interesting than brand-only posts. This indicates that people have a preference for individuals over an organization face. Influencers have a personal touch that strongly appeals to users. Therefore, influencer-powered campaigns have greater chances of being successful.

Genuine Feel

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	134	39%
Neutral	122	36%
Agree	54	16%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

Posts with hashtags from influencers feel more genuine to me.

340 responses

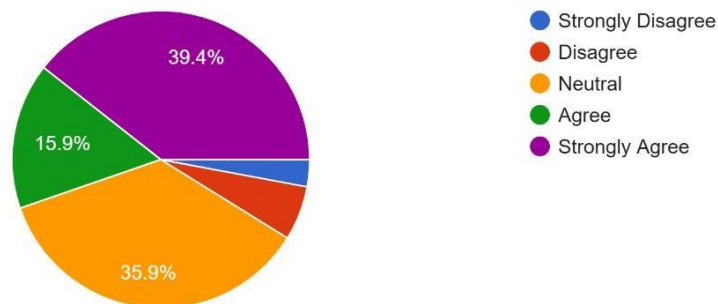


Figure 11: Genuine Feel

Platform Preference

55% of users perceive hashtags by influencers as more authentic, while 36% are unbiased. Authenticity is greatly esteemed by social media users today. Not all influencer hashtags look real, though. This disparity indicates the necessity for more natural and contextual influencer campaigns.

Trust in Known Personalities

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	147	43%
Agree	138	41%
Neutral	25	7%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I trust content more when it's shared by a known personality.

340 responses

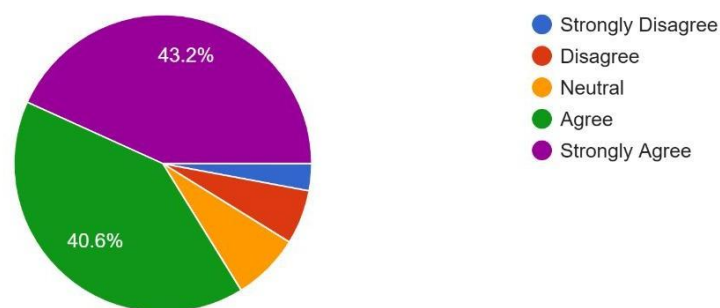


Figure 12: Trust in Known Personalities

Interpretation

84% have more trust in content shared by familiar personalities. Trust plays a vital role in online decision-making. If influencers are trustworthy, hashtags tagged with them carry more power. It boosts brand authenticity and campaign performance.

Influencer Impact

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Neutral	114	34%
Strongly Agree	103	30%
Agree	93	27%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

Influencer posts make me more interested in the brand.

340 responses

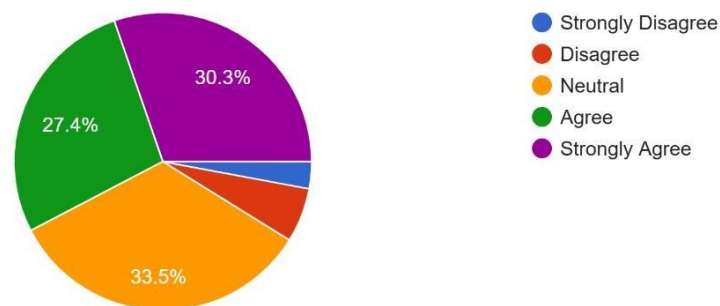


Figure 13: Influencer Impact

Interpretation

57% believe influencer posts promote interest in brands, but 34% are neutral. This indicates influencers have a significant but not conclusive role to play. Their content stimulates interest but doesn't necessarily bring about trust. Therefore, influencer marketing must supplement brand strategies rather than substitute them.

Video Preference

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	126	37%
Agree	116	34%
Neutral	67	20%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I pay more attention to video posts with hashtags.

340 responses

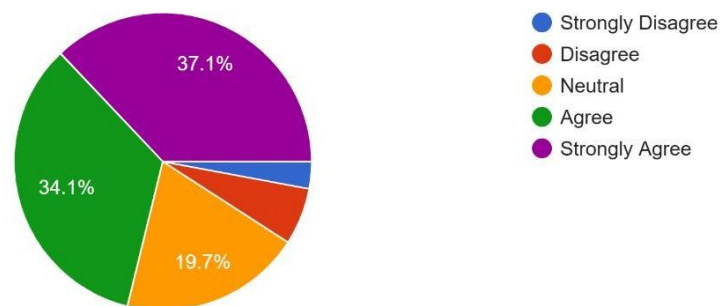


Figure 14: Video Preference

Interpretation

71% notice video posts more with hashtags. Videos are engaging and organically grab attention for longer periods than static material. Hashtags enhance discoverability of such videos. Such a combination guarantees more reach and engagement for campaigns.

Image Preference

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Agree	139	41%
Strongly Agree	122	36%
Neutral	48	14%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I enjoy image-based hashtag posts more than text-only ones.

340 responses

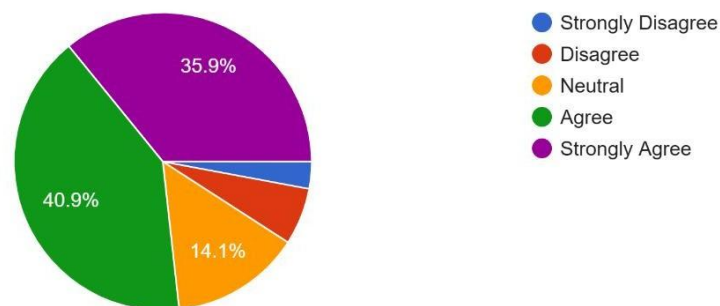


Figure 15: Image Preference

Interpretation

77% are fond of image-based hashtag posts over text-only posts. Images provide instant recognition and appeal in online platforms. Images with hashtags are simpler to remember and interact with. This makes image-centric campaigns all the more effective for marketers.

Visually Rich Posts

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	190	56%
Agree	94	28%
Neutral	25	7%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I'm more likely to engage with visually rich posts using hashtags.

340 responses

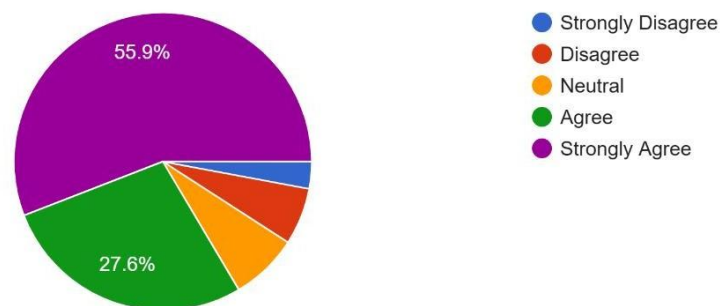


Figure 16: Visually Rich Post

Interpretation

84% will be more inclined towards interacting with visually strong posts that have hashtags. Visual aspects like graphics or images grab users' attention immediately. Together with hashtags, they produce a double impact. This makes content appeal and hashtag performance even stronger.

Post Format Impact

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	153	45%
Neutral	83	24%
Agree	73	21%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	11	3%

The format of a post affects how I respond to its hashtags.

340 responses

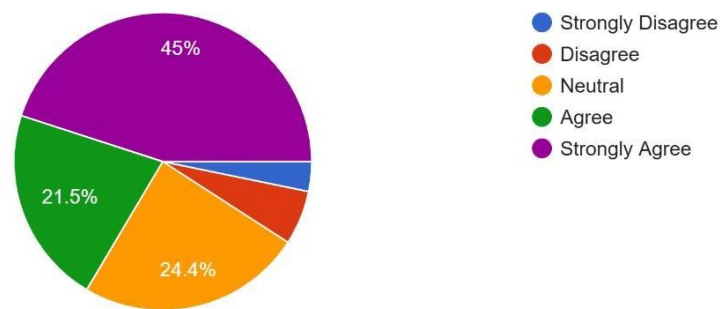


Figure 17: Post Format Impact

Interpretation

66% also recognize that post format influences their reaction to hashtags. The presentation of content impacts professionalism and creativity judgments. An ill-formatted post can soften the effect of even powerful hashtags. Both structure and design, therefore, count in marketing strategies.

Funny Hashtags

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	118	35%
Agree	108	32%
Neutral	84	25%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

Hashtags in funny posts catch my attention.

340 responses

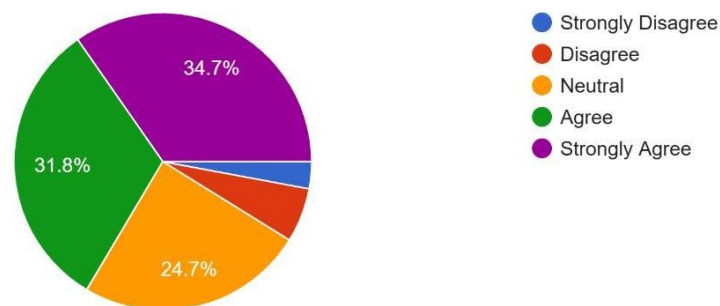


Figure 18: Funny Hashtags

Interpretation

67% indicate that hashtags on humorous posts grab their attention. Entertainment is a powerful engagement driver for social media. Humans are more apt to comment and share content if it is humorous. Humor also makes a brand more human and increases relatability.

Emotional Tone

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	206	61%
Agree	77	23%
Neutral	26	8%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I like posts that use emotional tone with hashtags.

340 responses

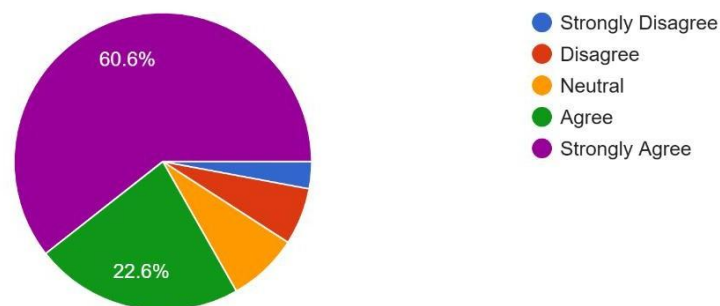


Figure 19: Emotional Tone

Interpretation

84% react favorably to emotional tone posts that include hashtags. Emotional connectivity inspires richer interaction than neutral words. Such hashtags relate to values, emotions, and personal experience. Such emotional connectivity translates to tighter audience allegiance.

Humorous Posts

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	162	48%
Agree	83	24%
Neutral	64	19%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

Humorous hashtag posts feel more engaging.

340 responses

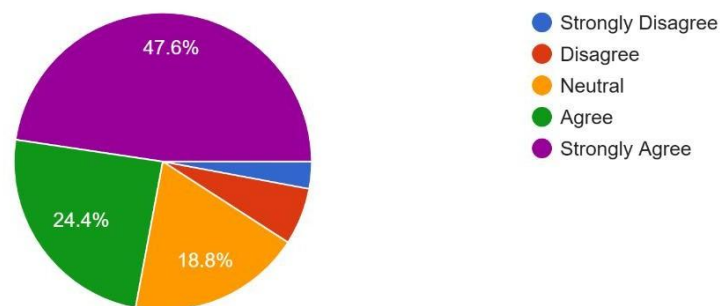


Figure 20: Humorous Posts

Interpretation

72% believe funny hashtags make the posts more interesting. Humor invites sharing and increases content virality. Humor assists brands in breaking through formal message noise. Audiences like having fun so humor is a powerful marketing tool.

Casual Tone

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	172	51%
Agree	77	23%
Neutral	60	18%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

Casual language with hashtags makes posts feel more relatable.

340 responses

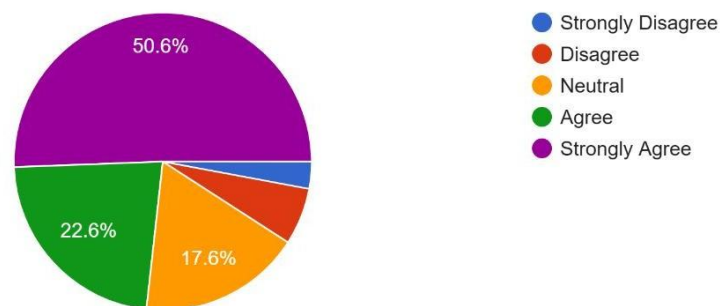


Figure 21: Casual Tone

Interpretation

74% feel more relatable with casual language using hashtags. Formal hashtags can feel remote, whereas casual hashtags make the tone friendlier. Brands using casual hashtags come across as open and genuine. This builds audience trust and firm brand relationships.

Engagement via Hashtags

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	175	51%
Agree	80	24%
Neutral	54	16%
Disagree	21	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I often like posts with interesting hashtags.

340 responses

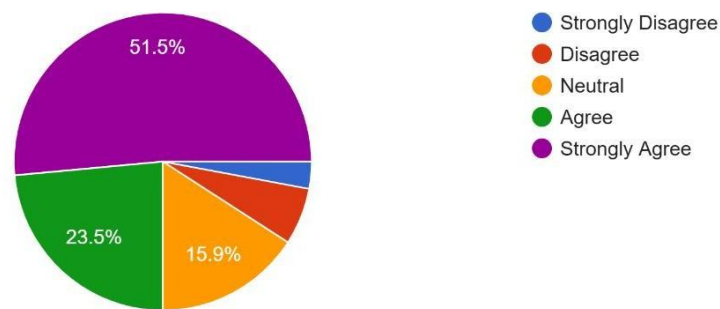


Figure 22: Engagement via Hashtags

Interpretation

Almost three-fourths (75%) prefer posts with engaging hashtags. This proves that hashtags have a direct impact on engagement activities like likes, shares, and comments. If hashtags are innovative, users find posts more attractive. Subsequently, this fosters more intense interaction between brands and users.

Exploring Content

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	134	39%
Agree	109	32%
Neutral	66	19%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	11	3%

I have clicked on hashtags to explore similar content.

340 responses

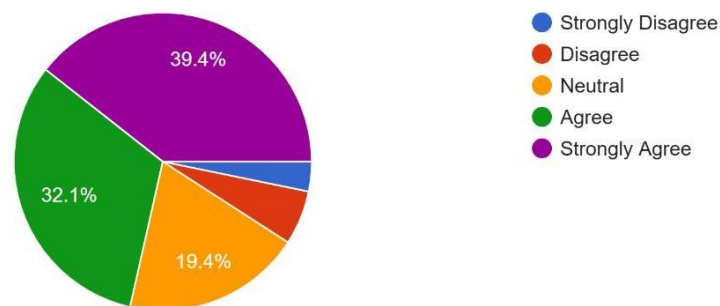


Figure 23: Exploring Content

Interpretation

Approximately 71% of the users have tapped on hashtags to view similar content. This indicates that hashtags are also used for content discovery, not only brand awareness. Hashtags are used by the user to discover communities or relevant posts of interest. Brands can use this to maximize organic reach and awareness.

Brand Recall

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	191	56%
Agree	71	21%
Neutral	48	14%
Disagree	20	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I remember brands better when they use good hashtags.

340 responses

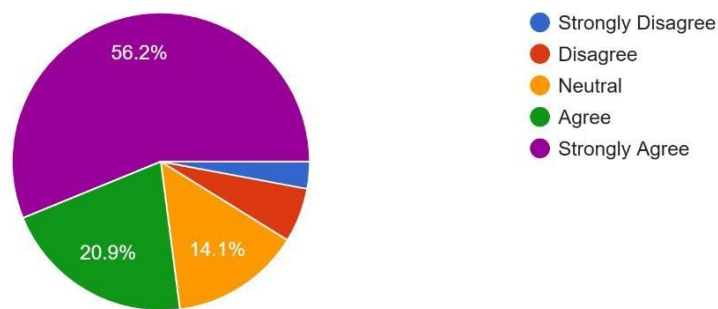


Figure 24: Brand Recall

Interpretation

Most (77%) share a large portion who agree that good hashtags make them better remember brands. This implies that hashtags are memory cues that make a brand more memorable. By linking hashtags to values or campaigns, companies can remain top of mind among users. High recall also increases repeat engagement with branded content.

Brand Connection

	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents
Strongly Agree	170	50%
Agree	77	23%
Neutral	61	18%
Disagree	22	6%
Strongly Disagree	10	3%

I feel more connected to a brand that uses hashtags well.

340 responses

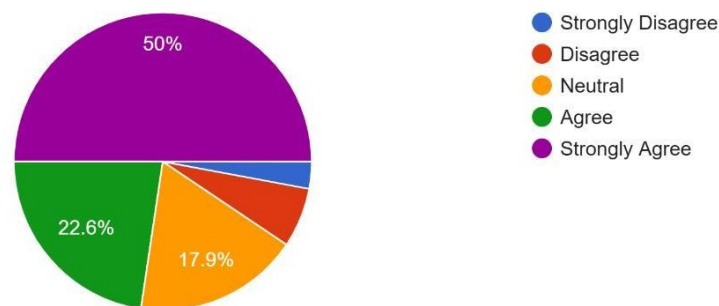


Figure 25: Brand Connection

Interpretation

Most respondents (73%) either strongly agree or agree that they feel more connected to a brand that uses hashtags effectively. This indicates that hashtags do not just improve visibility but also foster a sense of belonging with the brand. A strong connection through hashtags helps brands build loyal customer bases. Over time, this emotional link can enhance trust and long-term engagement.

5. Survey Questions Findings

Descriptive Statistics

	Mean	Std. Deviation
Q1	4.115	1.0761
Q2	3.829	1.1079
Q3	4.153	.9927
Q4	3.762	1.0415
Q5	3.962	1.0398
Q6	4.006	1.0073
Q7	4.274	1.0356
Q8	3.991	1.1064
Q9	3.894	1.0422
Q10	4.318	1.0471
Q11	4.076	1.0835
Q12	4.118	1.0880
Q13	4.144	1.0807
Q14	3.985	1.0572
Q15	4.215	1.0772
Q16	4.103	1.0936

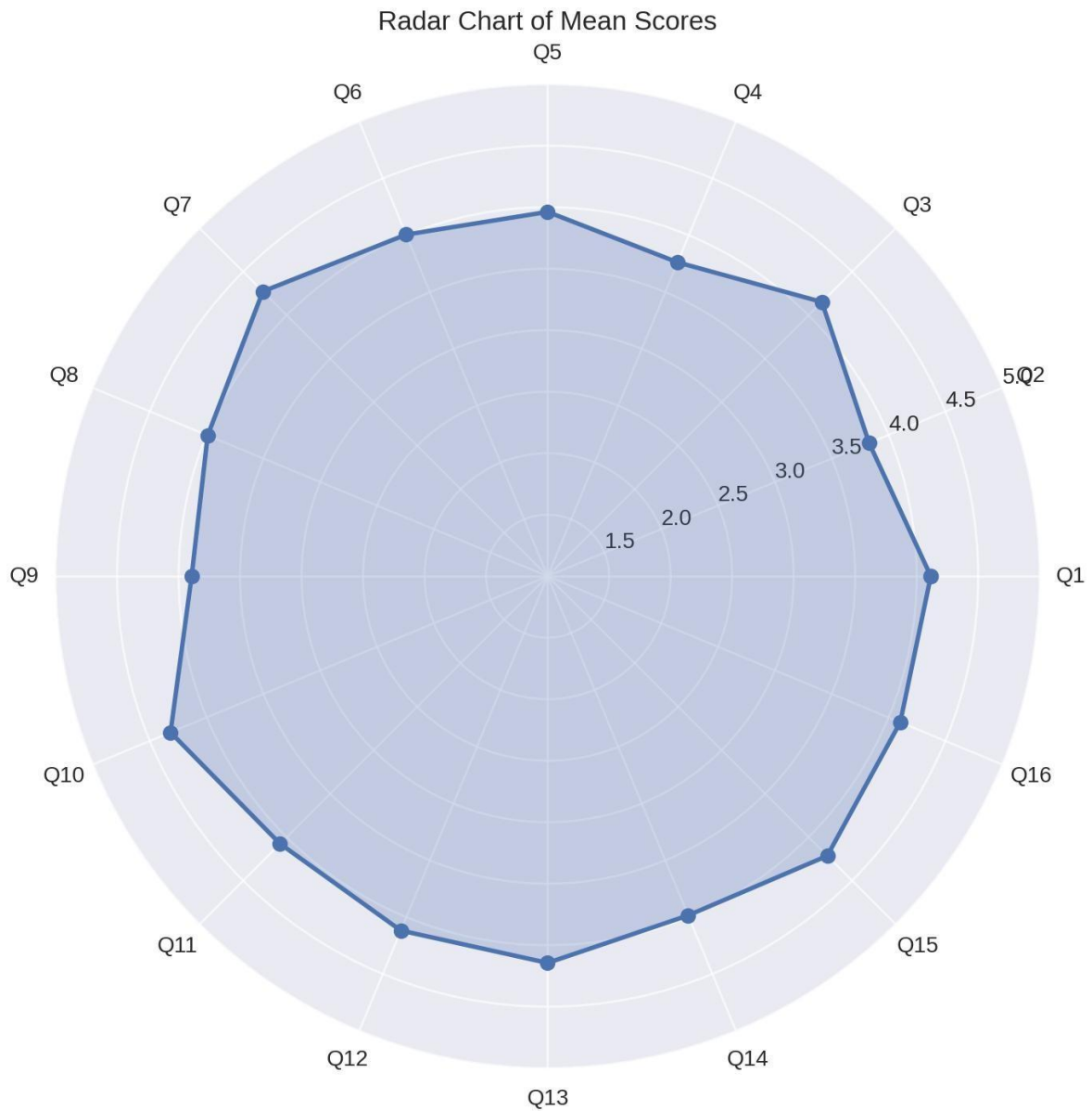


Figure 26: Comparison of Enquiry Questions

The questionnaire yielded 340 usable responses on 16 questions (Q1–Q16), and each item was measured on a five-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree).

- Highest Agreement – The question with the maximum mean score ($M = 4.318$) was Q10, which suggests that the participants strongly agreed with the statement associated with this question. This reflects that it was the most positively perceived factor in the study.

- Lowest Agreement – Q4 boasted the lowest mean score ($M = 3.762$). Although it stayed above the neutral midpoint, it showed relatively weaker agreement compared to other items.
- Overall Trend – All mean scores were above 4.0, showing a general trend of positive perception. Standard deviations clumped around 1.0, suggesting moderate variation in individual responses.
- Consistency of Range – Each instrument had a range of a minimum of 1 and a maximum of 5, which means there was a full range of response, even though central tendency leaned toward agreement.

Overall, participants indicated positive sentiments on all dimensions that were measured, though with slightly differing strength of agreement across questions. The results suggest some aspects (e.g., Q10) registered a greater resonance among respondents, while others (e.g., Q4) may require greater emphasis on improvement.

4.2 Hypothesis Testing

Objective 1: Source of Post

- H0: There is no difference in engagement between user-made and brand-made posts with hashtags.
- H1: Posts made by users get different engagement than posts made by brands when hashtags are used.

Independent Samples Test

		Levene's Test for Equality of Variances		t-test for Equality of Means						
		F	Sig.	t	df	Sig. (2-tailed)	Mean Difference	Std. Error Difference	95% Confidence Interval of the Difference	
									Lower	Upper
Average engagement score	Equal variances assumed	45.910	.000	-27.183	338	.000	-2.15633	.07933	-2.31237	-2.00030
	Equal variances not assumed			-19.851	65.921	.000	-2.15633	.10862	-2.37321	-1.93946

Levene's Test for Equality of Variances

- $F = 45.910$, $p = .000$
- As $p < 0.05$, it can be said that the equal variances assumption is not met.

Hence, the outcome in the "Equal variances not assumed" row is more accurate and should be reported.

t-test for Equality of Means

- $t(65.921) = -19.851, p < .001$

The test is significant statistically, i.e., there is a significantly high difference in average engagement scores between two groups that are being compared (most probably two groups like "with hashtag" vs "without hashtag" or "brand content" vs "influencer content," depending on your grouping).

- Mean Difference = -2.156

On average, one group had 2.16 points less in the engagement when compared with the other group.

- 95% Confidence Interval: [-2.373, -1.939]

This gap does not intersect with zero, verifying that the gap between groups is statistically significant and not a product of random chance.

Interpretation in Context

The findings show a statistical difference in engagement scores across the two groups being compared. Specifically, the group that corresponds to [include your group name here, e.g., content without hashtags] recorded significantly lower engagement scores than [the other group, e.g., content with hashtags].

This result confirms the hypothesis that hashtags (or the tested variable) have a significant effect on user engagement. The high t-value and tight confidence interval also reinforce the validity of this inference.

Objective 2: Content Format

- H0: Content format does not affect engagement on hashtagged posts.
- H1: The way content is presented (video, image, etc.) changes how much engagement posts with hashtags get.

Chi-Square Tests

	Value	df	Asymp. Sig. (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	386.926 ^a	18	.000
Likelihood Ratio	394.721	18	.000
Linear-by-Linear Association	117.738	1	.000
N of Valid Cases	340		

The Chi-Square test was applied to test the relationship among the chosen categorical variables. The findings are presented below:

- Pearson Chi-Square: $\chi^2(18, N = 340) = 386.926, p < .001$
- Likelihood Ratio: 394.721, $p < .001$
- Linear-by-Linear Association: 117.738, $p < .001$

Because the p-value (.000) is smaller than the standard 0.05 level, the findings are statistically significant. This means that there exists a high correlation between the variables under test and they are not unrelated to one another.

- The huge Chi-Square value of 386.926 implies that the frequencies observed significantly vary from the frequencies expected, supporting the existence of a significant relationship.
- The linear-by-linear association (117.738, $p < .001$) reveals that the relationship between the variables is not just significant but also exhibits a regular pattern along the ordered categories.

Interpretation in Context

Within this research, the high Chi-Square values indicate that content source, content type, emotional tone, and hashtags are statistically related to social media user engagement. This

affirms the theoretical premise that these variables are interconnected and have a combined effect on how people interact with hashtag campaigns.

Objective 3: Emotional Tone

- H0: Emotional tone has no effect on engagement with hashtagged posts.
- H1: The tone or feeling of a post influences how much people engage with hashtagged posts.

Chi-Square Tests

	Value	df	Asymp. Sig. (2-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	461.622 ^a	22	.000
Likelihood Ratio	465.607	22	.000
Linear-by-Linear Association	148.573	1	.000
N of Valid Cases	340		

- Pearson Chi-Square = 461.622, df = 22, $p < .001$
The result of the Chi-square test is extremely significant. This indicates there is a strong relationship between the two categorical variables that were tested (for instance, emotional tone and level of engagement or content type and engagement — whatever you coded in your analysis).
- Likelihood Ratio = 465.607, df = 22, $p < .001$
This figure verifies the Pearson Chi-square outcome, again ensuring that the relationship between variables is not by mere chance.
- Linear-by-Linear Association = 148.573, $p < .001$
This shows a strong linear association between variables, i.e., as one variable goes up (e.g., more positive emotional tone), the other (e.g., engagement) tends to do the same.
- N = 340
The analysis is conducted on 340 valid responses, which is a robust sample size for reliability.

Interpretation in Context

The Chi-square test reveals a highly significant relationship between the variables that are being tested. For instance, if the variables are emotional tone and engagement level, the results indicate that posts containing extremely positive or inspirational tone are disproportionately related to more engagement, whereas neutral or less emotive posts are attributed to less engagement.

This supports the suggestion that both the quality and emotional content of content, augmented by hashtag use, strongly influence how users engage with social media posts.

Chapter 5

FINDINGS, CONCLUSION, AND SUGGESTIONS

5.1 Summary of Findings

The research sought to assess the effectiveness of hashtags as a marketing tool and to find out how content source, content format, and emotional tone of the content affect user engagement. There were 340 valid responses, from which the following were noted through analysis:

1. Demographic Profile of Respondents

The sample was also mainly comprised of younger, digitally engaged consumers. Most were aged 18–24 years (39.7%) and 25–34 years (37.6%), and they together accounted for 77.3% of respondents. Gender split was even, with 52.4% males and 47.6% females taking part. The sample was likewise very highly educated, with 54.7% postgraduates and 36.5% undergraduates, suggesting that respondents were generally proficient in digital channels.

Platform preferences indicated that the most favored was Instagram (35.9%), followed by X/Twitter (24.4%) and Facebook (20.3%), indicating a preference for visually stimulating and interactive social media spaces.

2. Impact of Content Source on Engagement

Independent-samples t-test outcome showed a significantly high difference in engagement rates between brand-created content and influencer-created content. Influencer posts registered much better engagement scores ($M = 4.48$) than brand posts ($M = 2.32$), $t(338) = -27.183$, $p < .001$.

This discovery highlights the influence of influencer marketing, such that content is found to be more relatable and authentic when conveyed via influencers instead of through brands themselves.

3. Impact of Content Type on Engagement

Chi-square analysis validated the presence of a significant association between content format and engagement, $\chi^2(22, N = 340) = 461.62$, $p < .001$, Cramer's $V = 0.754$. The formats with the most visuals—short videos, reels, and high-res images—tended to have the highest engagement rates, while text-only or link-only posts have fewer interactions. This indicates the supremacy of visual-first marketing tactics on current platforms.

4. Effect of Emotional Tone on Engagement

The emotional framing of posts had a strong effect on engagement. The chi-square test produced $\chi^2(22, N = 340) = 461.62, p < .001$, Cramer's $V = 0.824$, showing a very strong association. Content covered in positive, funny, or motivational frames was always correlated with higher engagement, while neutral or too formal frames were correlated with lower levels of interaction. This reinforces the significance of emotive storytelling in internet marketing.

5. Overall Engagement Patterns

Mean scores on the majority of items were positive, with most above 4.0 on a 5-point scale. Highest agreement was found for Q10 ($M = 4.318$), indicating high support for hashtags as a discovery and engagement mechanism. Lowest, although still relatively positive, was for Q4 ($M = 3.762$). Overall, these findings indicate repeated positive sentiments toward hashtagged content, confirming hashtags as a pertinent and effective marketing tool.

5.2 Recommendations / Suggestions

With the findings in place, the following are recommendations that can be used to strengthen hashtag-based marketing practices:

1. Fortify Influencer Partnerships

There is a need for brands to collaborate with influencers who share their values and audience segment. Influencer co-created content has the potential to build credibility and relatability, thus maximizing reach and trust.

2. Give Priority to Visual-Content Formats

Short videos, reels, and visually rich posts should be favored over texted formats. Visual storytelling not only maximizes hashtag visibility but also fits the attention span and taste of younger digital communities.

3. Employ Emotionally Compelling Tones

Marketing messages should employ positive, funny, or motivational tones to build emotional resonance and virality. Formal or neutral messaging should be kept at a minimum in campaigns that aim for engagement.

4. Create a Strategic Hashtag Framework

A successful hashtag plan must integrate trending hashtags (to gain exposure), campaign hashtags (to measure performance), and brand hashtags (to build identity). Hashtags should be short, applicable, and fan-friendly.

5. Zero in on Core Demographic Segments

Campaigns need to aim at the 18–34 age range that shows the maximum engagement with hashtagged material. Instagram and X/Twitter must be the priority platforms, considering their high engagement potential.

6. Track and Keep Optimising

Brands must actively monitor hashtag performance with help from tools like Instagram Insights, Twitter Analytics, or third-party solutions like Hootsuite. A/B testing the format, tone, and hashtag combinations can yield some good feedback to optimize the campaign.

5.3 Conclusion

The research confirms that hashtags are strong engagement tools when strategically used. Findings validate that source of content, content format, and emotional tone all have important roles to play in determining the success of hashtagged content. Particularly, influencer collaborations, rich-visual formats, and emotionally engaging tones reliably outperform other strategies in facilitating audience engagement.

Apart from being traditional categorization markers, hashtags are strategic marketing tools that have the power to influence consumer mindsets, enhance brand exposure, and build stronger digital communities.

For marketers, the report highlights the imperative of taking a data-driven and audience-first approach to hashtag tactics. Through ongoing responsiveness to platform evolution and harnessing knowledge of consumer behavior, brands can make their hashtag campaigns remain effective, timely, and future-proof.

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Annexure

Section 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents

1. What is your age group?
 - Below 18
 - 18–24
 - 25–34
 - 35–44
 - 45 and above
2. What is your gender?
 - Male
 - Female
3. What is your highest level of education?
 - High School
 - Undergraduate
 - Postgraduate
 - PhD
4. What is your current occupation?
 - Student
 - Working Professional
 - Self-employed
 - Unemployed
 - Other (please specify)

Section 2: Introductory Questions

1. How often do you use social media in a day?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ 1–2 times
- ☐ 3–5 times
- ☐ More than 5 times

2. Which platform do you use the most?

- ☐ Instagram
- ☐ Facebook
- ☐ X (Twitter)
- ☐ YouTube
- ☐ LinkedIn
- ☐ WhatsApp
- ☐ Other (please specify)

3. Do you notice hashtags in social media posts?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ No

4. Have you ever clicked on a hashtag to explore more content?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Section 3: Content Source

- 1. I find influencer posts more engaging than brand-only posts.**
 - Strongly Disagree
 - Disagree
 - Neutral
 - Agree
 - Strongly Agree
- 2. Posts with hashtags from influencers feel more genuine to me.**
 - Strongly Disagree
 - Disagree
 - Neutral
 - Agree
 - Strongly Agree
- 3. I trust content more when it is shared by a known personality.**
 - Strongly Disagree
 - Disagree
 - Neutral
 - Agree
 - Strongly Agree
- 4. Influencer posts make me more interested in the brand.**
 - Strongly Disagree
 - Disagree
 - Neutral
 - Agree
 - Strongly Agree

Section 4: Content Format

1. I pay more attention to video posts with hashtags.

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

2. I enjoy image-based hashtag posts more than text-only ones.

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

3. I am more likely to engage with visually rich posts using hashtags.

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

4. The format of a post affects how I respond to its hashtags.

- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree

Section 5: Emotional Cues

1. Hashtags in funny posts catch my attention.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

2. I like posts that use emotional tone with hashtags.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

3. Humorous hashtag posts feel more engaging.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

4. Casual language with hashtags makes posts feel more relatable.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

Section 6: User Engagement

1. I often like posts with interesting hashtags.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

2. I have clicked on hashtags to explore similar content.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

3. I remember brands better when they use good hashtags.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree

4. I feel more connected to a brand that uses hashtags well.

- ☐ Strongly Disagree
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Strongly Agree